

HITTING THE GROUND...
A TVK leader inspects an Amma canteen, Kadayanallur; (right) Vijay with A.M. Shahjahan, first-ever IUML minister



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TAMIL NADU

MANY FIRSTS, AND SOME SECOND THOUGHTS

Team Vijay wears several colours, as Congress, VCK, IUML ministers bring novelty. Off stage, TVK cadre go a bit too vigilante

By **Kavitha Muralidharan**

FOR HIS A-DAY-AT-OFFICE PHOTOGRAPHS, going viral on handles like 'The Vijay Kingdom', he offers a picture of composed demeanour. But Tamil Nadu's new chief minister, C. Joseph Vijay, sits at the helm of a political experiment that's navigating many novelty elements. His Tamizhaga Vetri Kazhagam (TVK) ministry is no mono act—it's the first coalition government here in many years. The Congress is in office after decades; the Dalit-centred Viduthalai Chiruthaigal Katchi (VCK) and the Indian Union Muslim League (IUML) are in government for the first time ever. There's a notable absence: that of the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK) dissidents.

There's also a certain unofficial presence. The TVK cadre, drawn from Vijay's fandom, has exhibited its enthusiasm for reform a little too enthusiastically, recasting itself as a free-floating political gendarmerie of sorts. Videos circulating on social media show TVK members conducting impromptu inspections, intervening in local administration and behaving like parallel authorities. Earnest, if callow activism? Or excess produced by sudden access to power, as critics say? Either way, Vijay has been silent on the matter, stopping short of rebuking such behaviour.

MANY MEANINGS OF POWER

This mix of excitement and contradictions carries over to the politics proper. In a long-awaited fulfilment, the VCK's Vanni Arasu comes in as social justice minister, handling the Adi Dravidar Welfare and Hill Tribes departments. The IUML's A.M. Shahjahan is minister for minorities welfare. The two Congress ministers, Rajesh Kumar and Viswanathan, mark out a different trajectory. After years of being a non-playing, junior ally under the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK), the party now has a direct share in power in Tamil Nadu. In the optimistic reading, that validates the instincts espoused by sections in the party that see the TVK, rather than the DMK, as the emerging fulcrum of anti-BJP politics in the state.

Yet the decision comes with risks. Not only has the Congress alienated a long-time partner, it now has the onus of bringing stability and maturity to the new dispensation. That ambition has naturally not endeared it to the DMK. Leaders of the Left, VCK and IUML are learnt to have held discussions with the DMK brass before extending support to the TVK. Not so the Congress.

On cue, DMK president M.K. Stalin called up Vanni Arasu to congratulate him, but the Congress only copped trenchant criticism for being a "backstabber" that opportunistically shifted camp. Stalin's son Udhayanidhi, in particular, said the Congress had for years benefited electorally from its alliance with the DMK and then chosen